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for All of Us®



## MEETING MINUTES

**RE:** Mower County Comprehensive Plan  
Planning Advisory Committee Meeting #5

**Date of Meeting:** April 30, 2025

**Project Manager:** Nate Day

**Time of Meeting:** 5:30 to 7:00 P.M.

**SEH No.:** 180253

**Location of Meeting:** Grand Meadow City Hall  
Virtual

The following items were discussed at the above-referenced meeting (see attached presentation for additional reference):

### Minutes:

- Re-Introductions
- Engagement Updates
  - 247 survey responses
    - 180 complete
  - Economic Development related survey responses.
  - 45% of respondents are not supportive of additional taxes.
- Urban 3 Presentation discussion
- 2002 Comprehensive Plan
  - Economic Development Goals (2002)
    - Continuation of long-term commercial agriculture.
    - Attraction of jobs and commercial/industrial tax base to Mower County and the retention and growth of existing businesses.
    - Coordination of economic development activities among all units of government through DCA and agencies representing the small cities of the County.
  - Economic Development Policies (2002)
    - To facilitate, whenever possible, the coordination of economic development activities.
    - To continue to support the DCA as the countywide economic development planning and implementation agency.
    - To protect prime agricultural land from inappropriate use.

- To provide incentive opportunities to farmers to continue long-term commercial agriculture.
- Support the development of a countywide economic development plan that addresses commercial, industrial and agribusiness for both the rural and urban areas of the County.
- Explore the option of creating a countywide venture capital fund.
- Recognize the importance of an adequate housing supply in pursuing economic development activities.
- Work to ensure that Mower County continues to have access to state-of-the-art telecommunication infrastructure.
- Explore funding options to establish a high-tech telecommunications infrastructure fund.
- SWOT Analysis Exercise
  - See Attachment 2 for SWOT analysis exercise results.
- Draft Economic Development Goals
  - Ensure that Mower County is well-positioned to support future economic trends and maintain a top quality of life.
  - Retain, attract, and expand businesses that meet Mower County's needs and vision.
  - Attract and retain a highly skilled, adaptable workforce.
  - Continue to support and enhance agricultural and farming businesses in a sustainable manner.
- Next PAC Meeting
  - DATE: May 28, 2025
    - Finalize Public Services Policies
    - Finalize Transportation Policies
    - Draft Economic Development Policies
    - Draft Land Use and Natural Resources Goals

Attached Documents

1. Meeting Presentation
2. SWOT Analysis Results
3. LEHD Commuter Inflow/Outflow Graphic

# **Attachment 1: Meeting Presentation**

COMPREHENSIVE  
**PLAN**  
**2045**



# Planning Advisory Committee (PAC) Meeting #5

April 30, 2025



# Agenda

- **Re-Introductions**
- **Engagement Update**
- **Economic Development**
- **Next Steps**



# Engagement Update

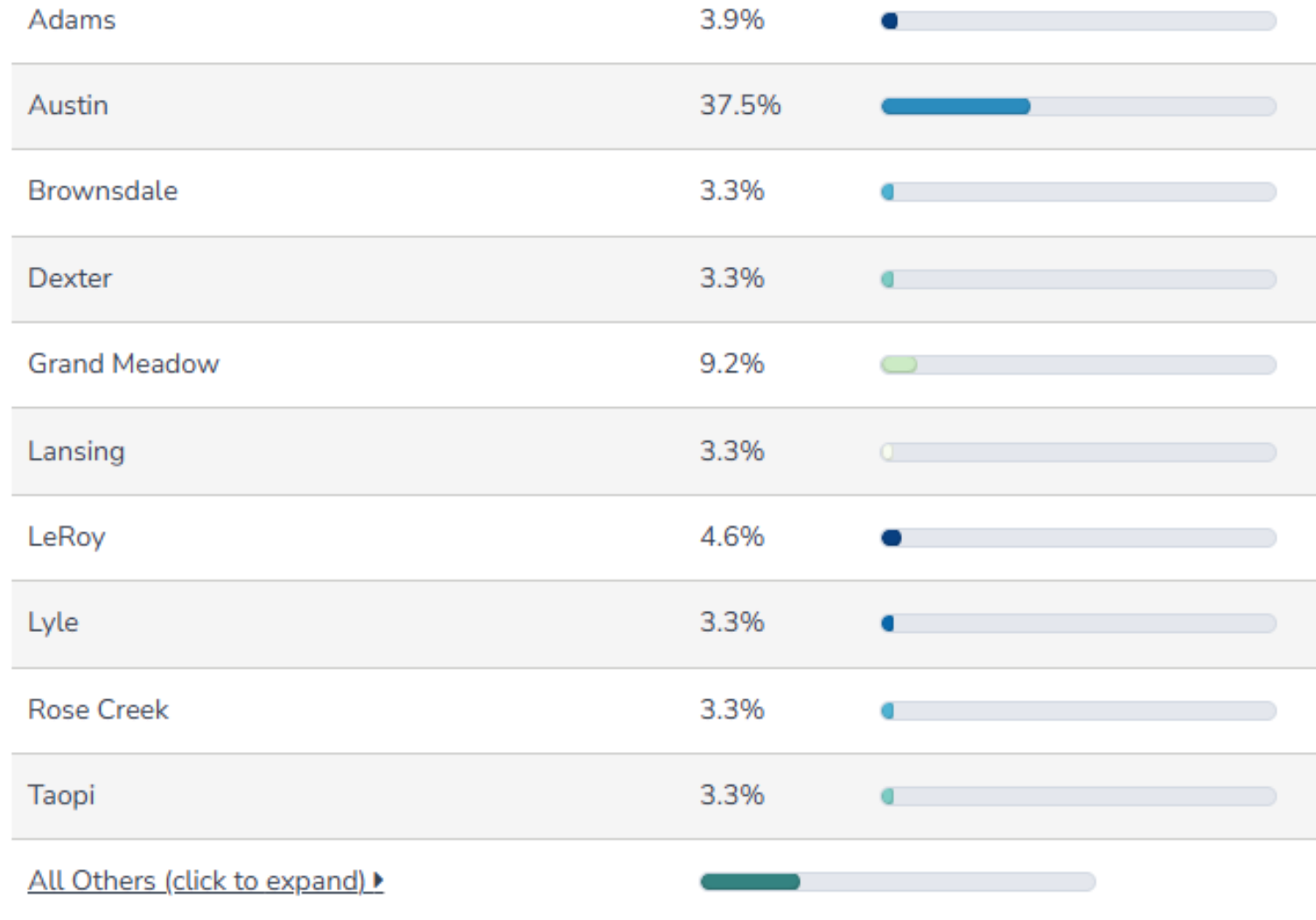


# Survey #2 Update



**247 survey participants**  
(180 complete, 67 partial)

[Click here to view a live summary  
of the Mower County survey #2](#)





# Survey #2 Update

| Value                                                                             | Percent |  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|--|
| I live in Mower County                                                            | 95.9%   |  |
| I work in Mower County                                                            | 44.4%   |  |
| I own a business in Mower County                                                  | 19.3%   |  |
| I live outside of Mower County, but I am interested in the County's future growth | 2.3%    |  |
| <u>Other - Write In (click to view)</u>                                           | 4.1%    |  |





# Economic Development



# Economic Development – Public Input

**60%**

Of respondents

Support limiting development to areas with infrastructure or near developed areas.

**75%**

Of respondents

support industrial development.

**78%**

Of respondents

agreed that it important to preserve the rural character throughout the County.

**63%**

Of respondents

agreed that it important to diversify the tax base.

**87%**

Of respondents

agreed that it important to protect agriculture and farming businesses.

**73%**

Of respondents

Support development of a regional food system.



# Economic Development – Public Input

**“Save our rural areas from being annexed into Austin.** Austin has enough space to build houses and apartments. If more subdivisions are needed - clean up the blighted areas in Austin first!”

**“Let's get more stores for us to shop.** Kids and grand kids come home to visit and we have to go to Rochester for school clothes. What ever happened to Harbor Freight?”

**“Better internet access to rural families** at affordable costs. Rural is lagging way behind”

**“Focus on attracting more manufacturing jobs** other than Hormel. They generally pay well and look at towns like Owatonna where manufacturing is large and the type of community they have become”

**“Growth will only happen when there is something to attract new residents.”**

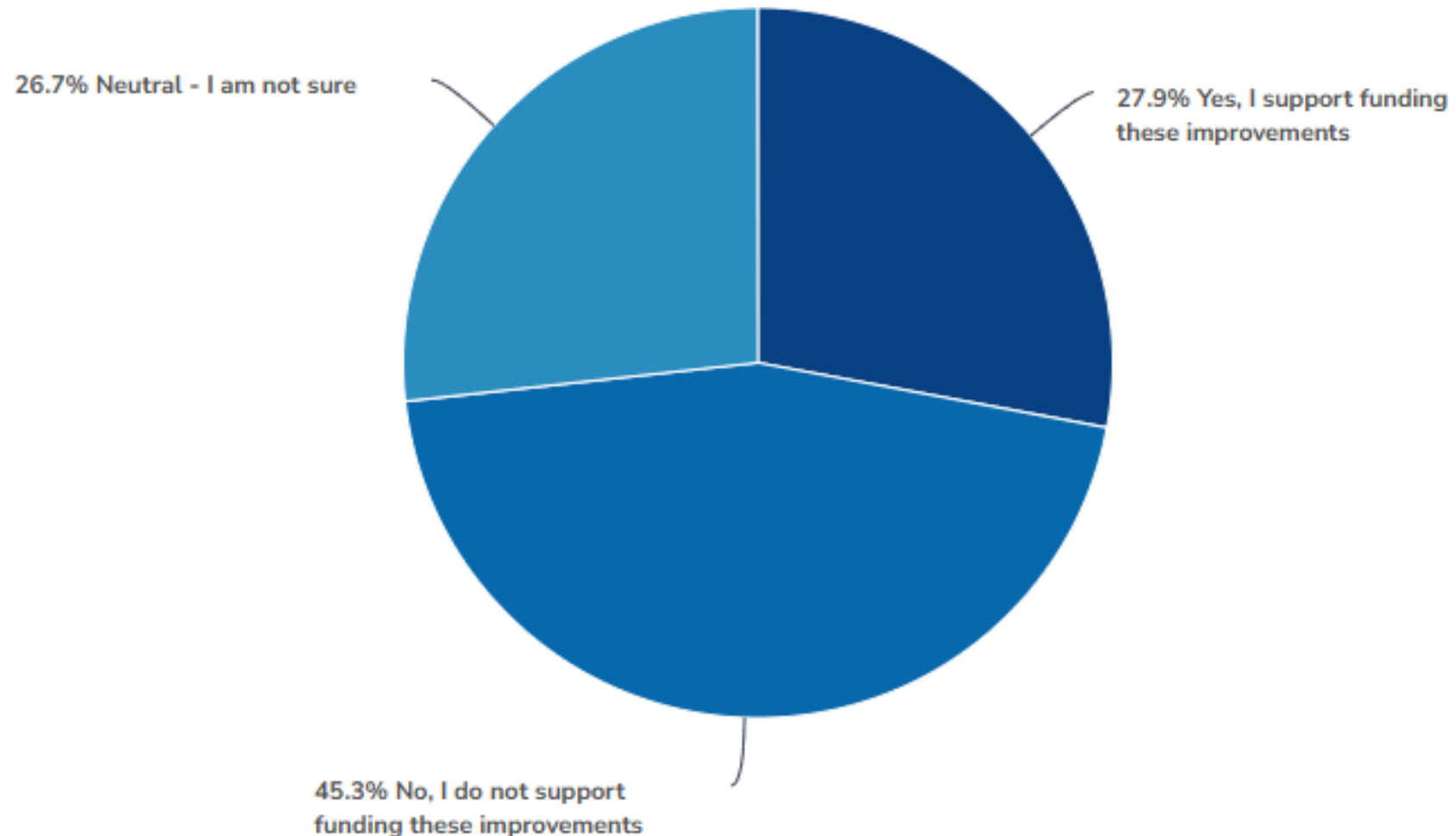
**“We must invest in sustainable agriculture!** Protecting our topsoil needs to be a top priority.”

**“Do not take away precious farmland** for housing or commercial development.”



# Economic Development – Public Input

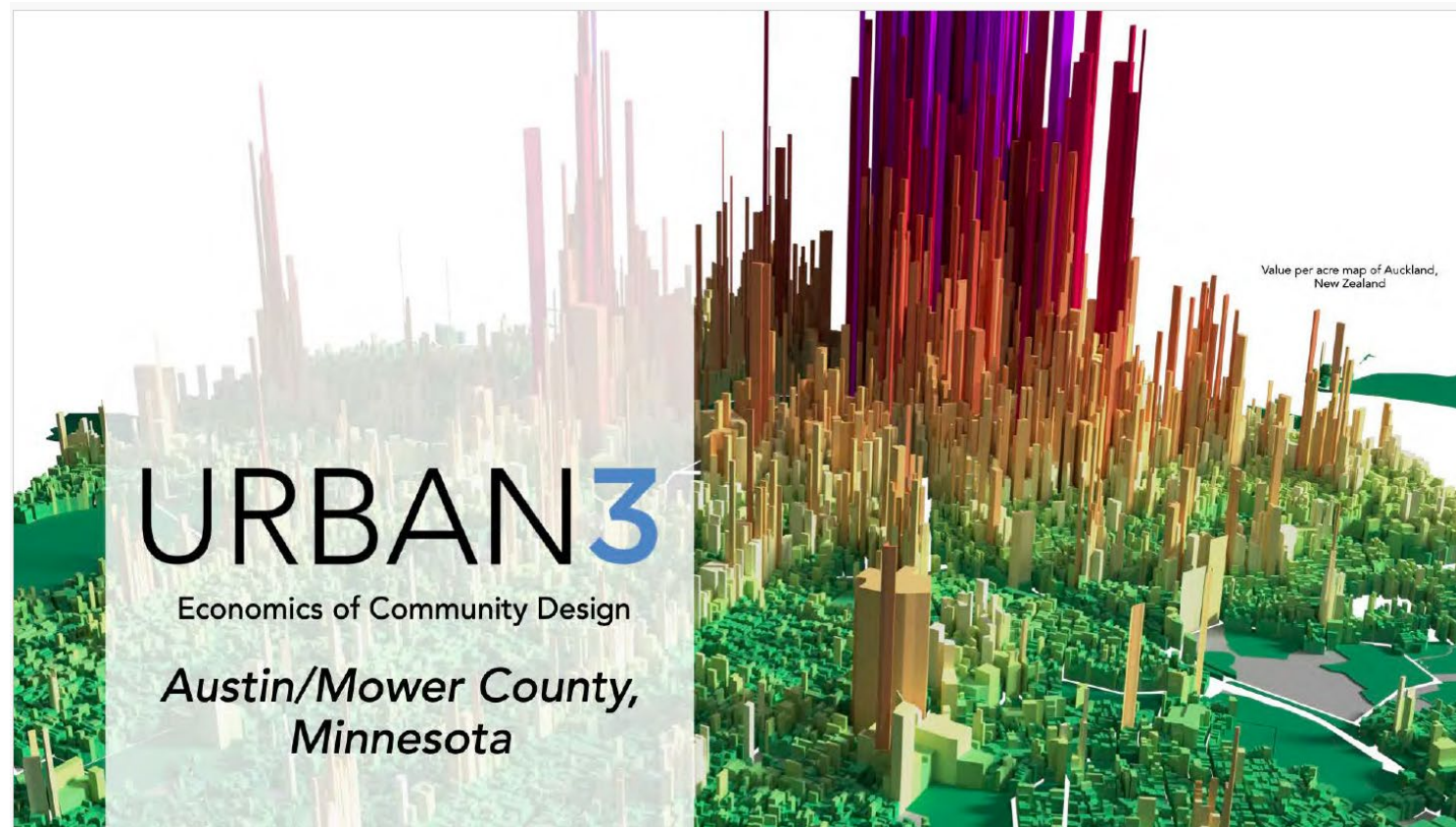
15. Would you support an increase in the county's tax levy to make these improvements in the community?





# Economics of Community Presentation

Urban 3 Presentation on February 18

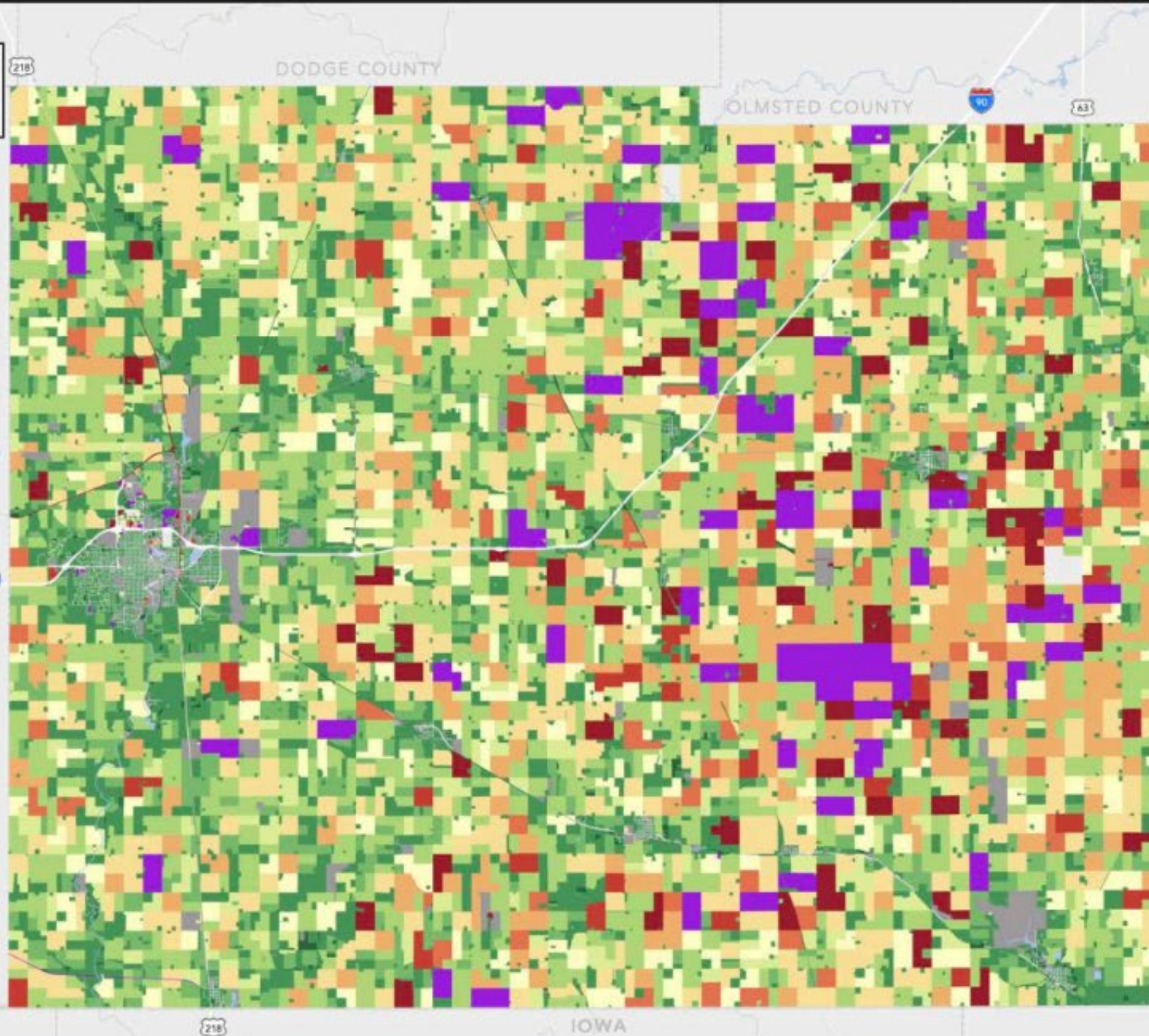


[View the presentation slides here.](#)

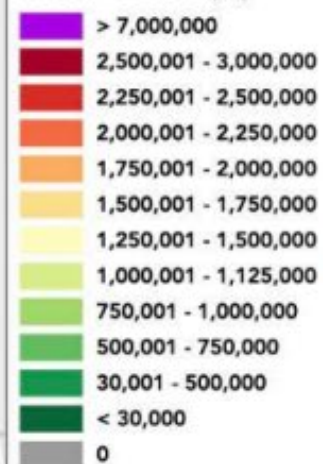


# Total Market Value

Mower County, MN



## Total Value (\$)





# Market Value Per Acre

Austin, MN

Brownsdale

Lansing

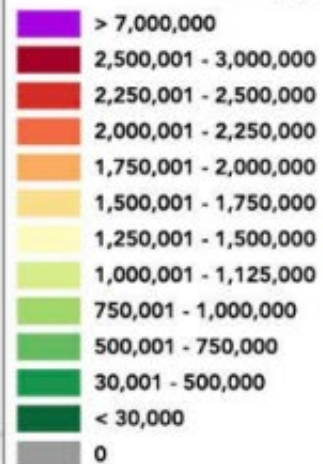
Austin

Racine

Grand Meadow

Le Roy

## Value Per Acre (\$)



DODGE COUNTY

OLMSTED COUNTY

FILEMORE COUNTY

IOWA



esri

# Market Value Per Acre

Mower County, MN



## Value Per Acre (\$)

- > 7,000,000
- 2,500,001 - 3,000,000
- 2,250,001 - 2,500,000
- 2,000,001 - 2,250,000
- 1,750,001 - 2,000,000
- 1,500,001 - 1,750,000
- 1,250,001 - 1,500,000
- 1,000,001 - 1,125,000
- 750,001 - 1,000,000
- 500,001 - 750,000
- 30,001 - 500,000
- < 30,000
- 0





# Austin/Mower County, MN: Value Per Acre Examples by Building Type

## Density

Low Medium High



\$0.7M



\$0.7M



\$1.0M



\$1.9M



\$1.9M



\$3.0M



\$4.4M



\$6.9M

Commercial

Residential

Commercial

Mixed Use

Residential

Residential

Mixed Use

Commercial

# Market Value Per Acre

Mower County, MN





# 2002 Comp Plan Economic Development Objectives

1. Continuation of long-term commercial agriculture.
2. Attraction of jobs and commercial/industrial tax base to Mower County and the retention and growth of existing businesses.
3. Coordination of economic development activities among all units of government through DCA and agencies representing the small cities of the County.





# 2002 Comp Plan Economic Development Policies

1. To facilitate, whenever possible, the coordination of economic development activities.
2. To continue to support the DCA as the countywide economic development planning and implementation agency.
3. To protect prime agricultural land from inappropriate use.
4. To provide incentive opportunities to farmers to continue long-term commercial agriculture.
5. Support the development of a countywide economic development plan that addresses commercial, industrial and agribusiness for both the rural and urban areas of the County.
6. Explore the option of creating a countywide venture capital fund.
7. Recognize the importance of an adequate housing supply in pursuing economic development activities.
8. Work to ensure that Mower County continues to have access to state-of-the-art telecommunication infrastructure.
9. Explore funding options to establish a high-tech telecommunications infrastructure fund



# SWOT Analysis

**STRENGTHS**

**WEAKNESSES**

**OPPORTUNITIES**

**THREATS**





# SWOT Analysis

**Go to Menti.com**

**Code: 8255 5712**

Questions to ask yourself?

- What defines Mower County? What are your favorite parts?
- What amenities are needed?
- What do we have now, but can be improved? What opportunities can become something bigger?
- What would you change about Mower County?





# Draft Economic Development Goals

1. Ensure that Mower County is well-positioned to support future economic trends and maintain a top quality of life.
2. Retain, attract, and expand businesses that meet Mower County's needs and vision.
3. Attract and retain a highly skilled, adaptable workforce.
4. Continue to support and enhance agricultural and farming businesses in a sustainable manner.



## Next Steps



# Next Steps

## Next PAC Meeting: May 28, 2025

- **Finalize Public Services Policies**
- **Finalize Transportation Policies**
- **Draft Economic Development Policies**
- **Draft Land Use and Natural Resources Goals**

## Next 90 days

- **PAC 6: May**
  - **Economic Development Policies**
  - **Land Use and Natural Resources Goals**
- **PAC 7: June**
  - **Land Use and Natural Resources Policies**
  - **Agriculture and Food City Goals**
  - **Agriculture and Food City Policies**
- **PAC 8: July**
  - **Housing Goals**
  - **Housing Policies**
  - **Implementation**
- **PAC 9: August**



A landscape photograph of a sunset over a field. The sun is low on the horizon, casting a warm orange glow across the sky and the field. The sky is filled with scattered clouds, some of which are illuminated by the sun. The field in the foreground is a golden-brown color, with visible furrows or rows of crops. In the distance, there are rolling hills and a few trees. On the left side, there is a small, dark structure that looks like a barn or a shed. The overall mood is peaceful and hopeful.

**Let's Plan Our Future.**



## **Attachment 2: SWOT Analysis**



# What are Mower County's **STRENGTHS**?

Low cost of living

Agriculture

Location (midway  
between twin cities and  
Des Moines)

Economic stability

Wind energy

Strong communities.

Agriculture

also close to Rochester



# What are Mower County's **STRENGTHS**?

Agriculture

Agriculture

Proximity to Rochester

educated workforce

Hormel

agricultural history

Quality education

Food and health  
research



# What are Mower County's **STRENGTHS**?

People, land resources,  
industrial businesses

Renewable energy

Convenience to urban  
areas

Green energy  
infrastructure

clean air, relatively clean  
water, open space

Relatively big enough size  
to be a super great place!  
We have enough people to  
support way more stores,  
restaurants, brewery, etc.

Road infrastructure

Good schools



# What are Mower County's **STRENGTHS**?

Hormel

Proximity to larger  
populations

Fiscal stability

Diversity

low tax rate; tax  
abatement program

Great roads

Lots of schools and  
Riverland

Lots of churches!



# What are Mower County's **STRENGTHS**?

Education opportunities

Entertainment

resistance to change



# What are Mower County's **WEAKNESSES**?

Lack of retail

Internet connectivity

Certain retail may be missing

Blighted areas

New industry

Lack of retail

Most retail and restaurants concentrated in Austin

Internet countywide



# What are Mower County's **WEAKNESSES**?

Not enough restaurants .  
Not a "restaurant scene"  
to draw people.

People opposed to  
change and other ideas

Outdoor recreation  
opportunities

Employee shortage

Beginner housing

lack of housing,  
particularly entry level  
housing

Housing shortage

Public school rankings  
and school ratings.



# What are Mower County's **WEAKNESSES**?

New industry

Having county seat centrally located

More recreational opportunities

Lack of transportation for those in need.

limited access to high speed internet

Getting noticed by the rest of Minnesota and the country

Aging infrastructure

Quite a bit of sub par houses.



# What are Mower County's **WEAKNESSES**?

State mandates,  
especially unfunded

transportation or access to  
services for low income or  
disabled populations

Deteriorating  
infrastructures

daycare shortage

We are too close to  
Rochester. This hurts us.

Challenges to starting  
new businesses

People going out of the  
county to shop/work

Walmart closed some  
local businesses.



# What are Mower County's **WEAKNESSES**?

No local food coop.

venture fund (development)  
out of Rochester reaches  
into NE Mower County



# What are Mower County's **OPPORTUNITIES**?

Sustainable agriculture

Ag business

Food and health  
research

Capitalize on ag that surrounds us by making a food city. Contact all farmers in the area and ask for their visions of this and what foods they could supply. They have energy and visions.

Improve the  
school/education  
ratings/rankings.

small, safe communities

Without at least an average school rank, young workers starting families will not be drawn here.

Could we do an incentive to cleanup yards and spruce up housing?



# What are Mower County's **OPPORTUNITIES**?

access to major highway  
and rail lines

Community interaction,  
ie cooperation between  
communities

Lots of potential  
development in Austin  
and other communities

investment in farm to  
market, food systems

Cedar River

connectivity of bike  
trails

More recreational areas,  
trails, etc, and  
connections between  
them

State Park



# What are Mower County's **OPPORTUNITIES**?

Promote the county  
better as a great place  
to live

Desire from the  
communities to grow

Local food production

FAARM U OF M

Volunteer organizations

Housing development,  
especially nearer  
Rochester

Non-profits, generous  
community members

Hormel foundation



# What are Mower County's **OPPORTUNITIES**?

FAARM and Riverland -  
education, maybe  
housing/growth  
opportunity

We could make Austin  
healthier. Do a big  
community push for healthy  
eating?

FAARM coming

Interstate, US, MN  
highway for  
transportation logistics



# What are Mower County's **THREATS**?

Aging population

Aging infrastructure and  
lack of funding

Closeness of Rochester.

Unfunded state  
mandates.

FAARM people landing  
in Owatonna

Lack of population  
growth

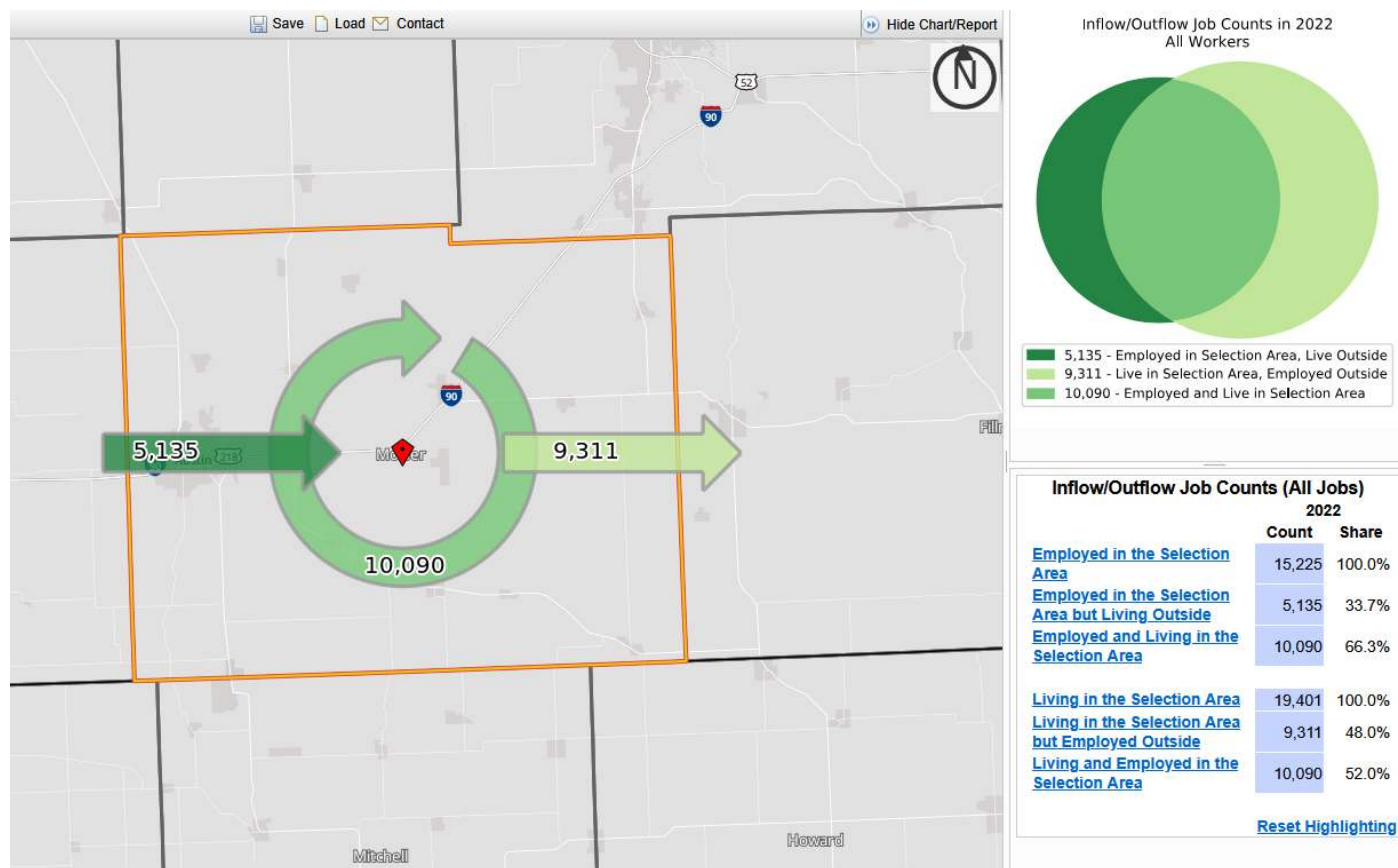
Weather challenges

more frequent drought  
(Ag)



## **Attachment 3:**

# **LEHD Commuter Inflow/Outflow Graphic**



Screenshot of the United State Census Bureau’s “Inflow/Outflow Analysis in 2022.” 5,135 individuals travel into Mower County for work, 9,311 travel outside of the county and 10,090 reside and work in the county. The arrows do not indicate direction.

Source: <https://onthemap.ces.census.gov/>